acting by command of an anonymous council. (Although it has been argued that the grain of Abul Fazl's narrative is exactly this, that Akbar is right no matter what. As Peter Hardy puts it memorably: 'Whatever Akbar is, is for the best; whatever Akbar does is for the best; but the best is what, from moment to moment, Akbar is and does.' Akbar's actions do not follow precepts, that is, they are principles in themselves.)[13]

Even if there were good reasons behind Akbar's order to arrest the Kashmiri king to whom Bhagwant Das had promised safe passage, the Rajput did not approve of them. Twice in the following weeks, Bhagwant Das had fits of 'madness'.[14]

First, when he was given command of Kabul, he proclaimed 'improper desires', writes Abul Fazl, without elaboration. The modern historian Afzal Husain suggests that Bhagwant Das may have demanded guarantees for his authority in Kabul, to avoid the dishonour of having his word broken on his behalf again.[15] If so, no such promise was forthcoming; instead, Akbar cancelled the Rajput's appointment. Bhagwant Das apologized, was reappointed, but '[became] mad' once again after crossing the Indus. He was brought back to the fortress of Attock where, while a doctor took his pulse, the overwrought Rajput tried to stab himself.

Again, Abul Fazl offers no explanation except insanity. While it is true enough that, for Abul Fazl, anyone who cannot see the perfect rightness of all Akbar's actions qualifies 'for admission to the Mughal equivalent of a psychiatric hospital with maximum security',[16] there was a strain of mental illness that ran in Bhagwant Das's family. Two of his children, including Akbar's daughter-in-law, would also try, and succeed in, killing themselves. It may have been manic depression that drove Bhagwant Das's hand to his dagger, but the Rajput had reason for his unhappiness. Badauni, more plain-spoken, as always, writes that Akbar had broken his amir's pledge, and Bhagwant Das was willing to end his life 'to save his . . . sense of honour'.

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Akbar had grieved his Rajput kin; but the emperor, too, was grieving. It was only a few weeks before Bhagwant Das's return from Kashmir that Akbar received news of Birbar's death.

Twice Akbar had saved Birbar's life. Once, in 1583, when Birbar fell off